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Affinity Wall Findings Report
Really Great Reading - Blast Phonics Program

Product Summary:
Really Great Reading's phonics program, Blast, is a tool that teachers can use daily in their classrooms. It is mostly used in Kindergarten-3rd grade classrooms. Their students are able to log into personal accounts with individualized assignments created by the Really Great Reading company. The students complete assignments independently on their own computers. These assignments are a supplemental tool expected to be used in conjunction with phonics instruction guided by the teacher.
Although Blast is a wonderful tool, I suspect many teachers have trouble getting their students set-up on the program as I personally had a difficult time navigating the website and getting started. Teachers may have trouble allocating pre-paid licenses to students, finding the teacher dashboard, locating the student login page, generating student passwords, unlocking new levels, and teaching students how to navigate their new program.

Overarching Question:
What are some challenges teachers experience while getting their students started on Really Great Reading's program "Blast"?

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This report will address the findings from interviews conducted to answer the overarching questions, "What are some challenges teachers experience while getting their students started onReally Great Reading's program Blast?" Included in this report are two key findings including Student Navigation Through Program Levels and Finding and Changing Student Passwords.

Key Finding 1 – Student Navigation Through Program Levels
All participants in this study experienced some complications when guiding their students to move through the multiple levels of the Blast phonics virtual program. The default setting is the first two levels are unlocked for students. Participant 2 noticed that students move through the content quicker than expected, so they needed to unlock multiple levels at once. They unlocked levels 1-12, but then had to stop because they didn't have enough time to do the rest.

Participant 1 came to the same conclusion that more levels needed to be unlocked, but they said unlocking new levels is "cumbersome" and requires too many clicks. Participant 3 unlocked only the next level for each student in their class before noticing the "apply to every student in this class" button. Participant 3 also mentioned that they wish each level could be clicked on and "previewed" to see which level(s) aligned best with the phonics content they were teaching at the time. Because all the levels were unlocked, Participant 1 said their students were completing the levels out of order and attempting activities from multiple different levels, rather than following the flow of one level's content all the way through. The teacher said this takes away from the student's progress and proficiency. Lastly, All participants mentioned that their students had a hard time moving on past the final stage at each level where they "free build" words.

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Recommendations
Because it is a feature that it seems most users utilize and appreciate, the “apply to every student in this class” button should be a pop-up notification so that it is not missed by users. Additionally, there could be more control given to student users. The ability for a student to click “unlock next level” when they have finished all prior content would save the teachers from having to complete the process and would allow them to better serve individualized instruction to their students.

On the final level, have directions informing the user of what to do/where to navigate to next.

Key Finding 2 – Finding and Changing Student Passwords

The participants expressed concerns with the level of complexity when it comes to finding and changing student passwords. Participant 1 couldn’t find the arrow to se additional student info. The arrow is located beyond the field of view, and the user must scroll horizontally to find it. Participant 1 also noticed that the “View Class Roster” and My Students pages look similar with a list of all student names and a menu displayed by the 3 vertical dot symbol. When they were trying to reset passwords, they kept accidentally clicking the 3 dots on the “My Students” page where regenerating a password is not an option. When the user is in the “View Class Roster” page and they click on a student to view their password information, when the user clicks the back button, it does not return them to the “View Class Roster” page, it takes them to the “My Students” page. This page looks very similar, but is not the right location to find the menu for regenerating student passwords.

Recommendations

Make more of a contrast in the appearance between the “View Class Roster” page and the “My Students” page.

Choose a different symbol than 3 dots for one of the menus.

Return the user back to the page they were on when they click the back button.